Your 6-week hip and knee strengthening programme

Five exercises a session, three sessions a week. Each week builds on the last.

Name _____ Physiotherapist _____ Start date _____

How to use this programme

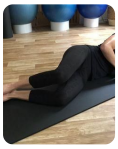
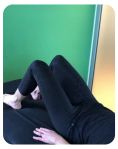
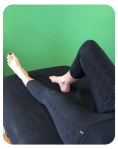
- Do the exercises **three times a week**, with a rest day in between (for example Monday, Wednesday, Friday).
- Move slowly and with control. Quality matters more than speed.
- Rest 30–60 seconds between sets.
- Tick a box each time you finish a session.
- Move on to the next week only when the current week feels manageable.

The 3/10 pain rule

- Some discomfort is fine. On a scale of 0 (no pain) to 10 (worst pain imaginable), keep it at **3/10 or below** while you exercise.
- Your symptoms should be **no worse the next morning**.
- If pain goes above 3/10, or you are worse the next day, stay on the same week or go back a week.
- If pain keeps increasing, stop and contact your physiotherapist.

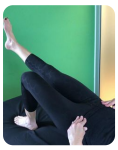
Week 1 Gentle activation

Sessions done ☐☐☐

	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS / TIME
	**Clamshell** Lie on your side with hips and knees bent and feet together. Lift the top knee like a clamshell opening, without rolling your hips back. Lower slowly.	3	10
	**Side-lying hip abduction** Lie on your side. Keep the top leg straight, slightly behind you, toes pointing forward. Lift the leg up, without rolling your hips back, then lower slowly.	3	10
	**Bridge** Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat. Push through your heels to lift your hips until knees, hips and shoulders are in a line. Hold for a moment, then lower slowly.	3	10
	**Straight-leg raise** Lie on your back with one knee bent. Turn the straight leg slightly out, tighten the thigh muscle to lock the knee, and lift the leg to the height of the other knee. Lower slowly.	3	10
	**Squat to a chair (quarter depth)** Stand in front of a chair. Sit your hips back and down a quarter of the way, then stand up. Keep your knees in line with your toes.	3	10

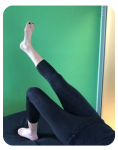
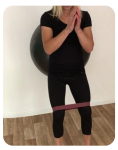
Week 2 Adding resistance

Sessions done ☐ ☐ ☐

	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS / TIME
	**Clamshell with band** As above, with a resistance band just above your knees.	3	15
	**Hip rotation lying face down (inward, band)** Lie on your front with one knee bent to 90° and a band around the ankle. Move the foot inward across the other leg against the band, keeping your hips flat. Return slowly.	3	10
	**Bridge with alternating leg lifts** Lift into a bridge. Keeping your hips level, straighten one knee, then put it down and swap sides.	3	10 each side
	**Wall slide with ball squeeze (quarter depth)** Lean your back against a ball on the wall, with a small ball between your knees. Squeeze the ball and slide a quarter of the way down. Hold.	3	30 s hold
	**Squat to a chair (half depth)** As above, going about halfway down, lightly touching a higher chair or cushion.	3	15

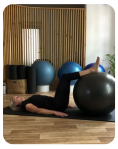
Week 3 Stronger bands, part-range

Sessions done ☐ ☐ ☐

	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS / TIME
	**Side steps with band** Band around your feet, knees straight, toes forward. Step sideways, keeping your body upright. Don't let the band snap your feet together.	3	10 steps each way
	**Hip rotation lying face down (in and out, stronger band)** As in week 2, with a stronger band: move the foot outward against the band, then inward. Keep your hips flat.	3	10 each way
	**Single-leg bridge** Lie on your back with knees bent. Straighten one leg and push up through the other heel until hip, knee and shoulder line up. Lower slowly.	3	10 each side
	**Squat (half depth)** Feet hip-width apart. Sit your hips back and down to about halfway, knees in line with your toes. Stand up pushing through the whole foot.	3	10
	**Wall slide with band (quarter depth)** Back against a ball on the wall, band above your knees. Slide a quarter of the way down, pushing your knees out against the band.	3	10

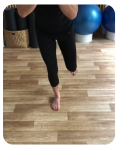
Week 4 Single-leg and step work

Sessions done ☐☐☐

	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS / TIME
	**Fire hydrant** On hands and knees, lift one bent knee out to the side without leaning or twisting your body. Lower slowly.	3	10 each side
	**Bridge with feet on a ball** Heels on a gym ball. Lift your hips and hold, keeping the ball still.	3	30 s hold
	**Side step-up** Stand side-on to a step. Step up sideways onto it, then lower slowly. Keep your hips level and your knee over your foot.	3	10 each side
	**Step-down (low step)** Stand on a low step. Slowly lower the other heel to touch the floor, keeping the standing knee over your second toe and hips level. Push back up.	3	10 each side
	**Lunge (quarter depth)** Step forward and bend both knees a quarter of the way down, keeping the front knee over your foot. Push back to standing.	3	10 each side

Weeks 5–6 Balance and full range

Sessions done ☐☐☐☐☐☐

	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS / TIME
	**Bridge with ball roll-in** Heels on the ball, lift your hips. Keeping them up, curl the ball in towards you and roll it back out.	3	10–15
	**Y-balance reach** Stand on one leg. Reach the other foot forward, back-and-in, and back-and-out, touching lightly. Keep the standing knee over your foot.	3	5 each direction, each side
	**Lunge with band pull** Hold a lunge position with a band pulling your front knee sideways. Don't let the knee move: keep it over your second toe.	3	30 s each side
	**Step-down (higher step)** As in week 4, from a higher step.	3	15 each side
	**Lunge (to 90°)** Lunge down until your front knee is bent to 90° at most. Push back to standing.	3	15 each side

Your physiotherapist may change exercises, sets or reps to suit you; follow their advice over this sheet. Videos of every exercise are in the Running Gait Analysis course exercise library. Programme adapted from Ferber R, et al. J Athl Train. 2015;50(4):366–377. · Core Learning